

Why does my brain go to a meme when I don't have the words?

Pilar Liotta · MS2 · 2026

I grew up using memes to cope with things I couldn't say out loud.

Shared language for things that are too heavy, too awkward,
or too absurd to say out loud

Making sense of things together through a joke

A way of saying something true when saying
it directly feels like too much

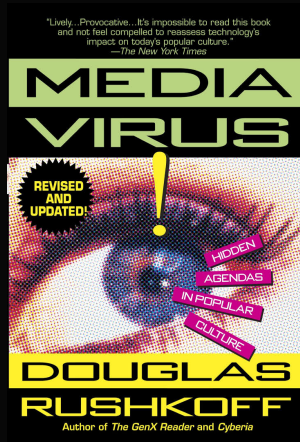
But It's Not Just Me.

Millions of people reached for the same image
It's a collective psychological event.

*When everyone sends "This Is Fine" at the same time,
the meme becomes structure for shared feeling.*



Thinking Behind This



Douglas Rushkoff

Memes spread like viruses - they replicate through networks whether you understand them or not



Shira Chess

Sharing an image online is closer to ritual than communication and internet culture runs on magical thinking

log off challenge failed

i'm tired of this timeline

it be like that



Timothy Leary

Every time an idea is transmitted it changes, the receiver processes it through their own experience and passes something different forward

What happens to that language over time?

touch grass



Original



Screenshot



Repost



Compressed



Deep Fried



Meaning
Lost

Early — Original meaning

People knew the origin

Cartoonist KC Green created "Question Hound" in 2008 for his webcomic series Gunshow.
Metaphor for Green's own mental health struggles.

Middle — Detached format

Origin forgotten, just relatable

"Me during finals.
Me during literally anything."

Later — Makes no sense

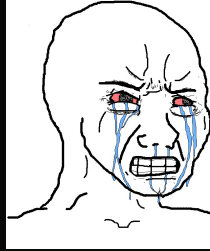
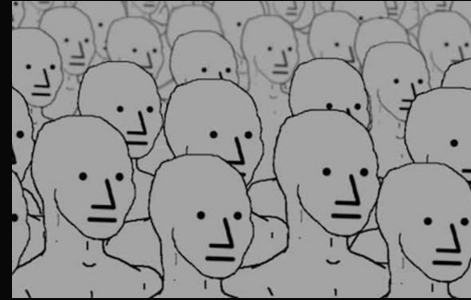
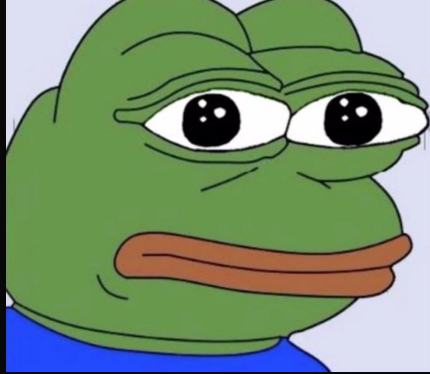
Meaning fully doesn't matter

"lol real"
"this is fine" [no context]



Five case studies (Memes):

This Is Fine, Pepe, Doge, NPC, Crying Wojak.



Each one started as one thing and became something else entirely

This Is Fine — started as grief, became a reaction to everything. Now means nothing.

Pepe — started innocent, got claimed as a hate symbol

Doge — became a cryptocurrency, by tech bros

NPC — used to tell people they weren't real

Crying Wojak — turned real feeling into a costume

i feel nothing

lol i actually hate it here

i'm tired of this timeline

real

The Sketch Lives On Your Phone.

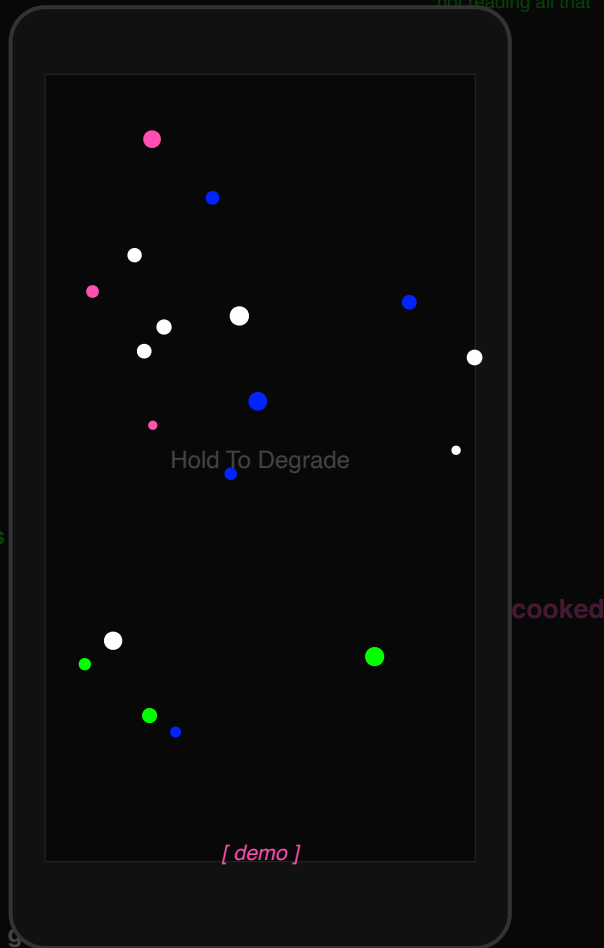
Choose a meme. Hold to degrade it.
Watch it fall apart in your hand.

Bleed Particles/Glitches

Comments and context from the meme's real history bleed out as it degrades

Degradation Stages

Follows the meme from its original meaning to total noise and the longer you hold, the more it breaks down.



Questions for You!

- 1 Does a meme losing its meaning feel like It's finally being let go off?
- 2 What meme have you shared when you didn't have words?
- 3 I'm building a catalog — This Is Fine, Pepe, Doge, NPC, depression formats. Does that selection feel right?

i feel nothing

real

lol i actually hate it here

i'm tired of this timeline

send memes

cope

this is exhausting

Prototype

[Link to P5js](#)

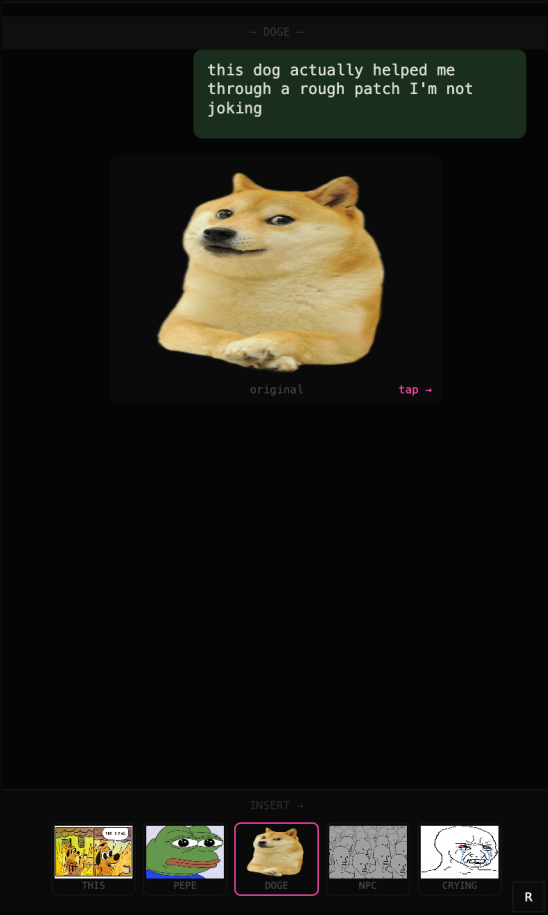
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send memes